

A Charter for Accountable Use of AI in Canadian Healthcare:

Co-designed with patients and caregivers

December 2025



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Promouvoir l'équité et l'inclusion dans les soins de santé en accélérant l'utilisation responsable de l'intelligence artificielle est financé par le gouvernement du Canada dans le cadre du programme Compétences futures.

This Charter was created in collaboration with the AI in Healthcare Patient Charter Advisory Committee.
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Message from the Advisory Committee

Patient Partners and knowledge experts from across Canada came together throughout 2025 with the shared goal of understanding what matters most to patients and caregivers when [artificial intelligence \(AI\)](#) is used in healthcare.

Through a meaningful patient engagement process, we are proud to share: *A Charter for Accountable Use of AI in Canadian Healthcare: Co-designed with patients and caregivers.*

This [Charter](#) is for patients, [healthcare providers](#) and [healthcare organizations](#). It aims to support relationships with each other and with AI industry partners. It describes the values and behaviours that patients and caregivers said are most important for building trust in an AI-enabled healthcare system.

As said by a committee member, “the charter can become a national anchor for trust in AI-enabled care. An evidence-based, shared language that sets clear expectations, centres equity, and supports transparent, human-centred implementation. Its impact goes beyond technology, it reshapes culture, governance, and patient partnership for years to come”.

This work was driven by our shared commitment to make a meaningful impact on the healthcare system. This journey has left us feeling hopeful, connected, and inspired.

Our shared hope is for the Charter to make an **impact** in the following ways:

- **Serve as a moral compass** that provides direction for AI use in fair, safe and ethical ways.
- **Bring together patients, caregivers, healthcare providers and leaders** to build a trusted, accountable AI-enabled healthcare system that reflects patient needs.
- **Guide healthcare organizations** to prevent [bias](#) and harm.
- **Set clear actions** that patients and caregivers expect from their healthcare providers and organizations to build and maintain trust.
- **Build skills and knowledge in healthcare providers about AI**, so they can better support patients and caregivers.
- **Initiate and sustain safe and honest conversations** between organizations, providers, patients, caregivers and communities. Ensure everyone's voice is heard when building an AI-enabled health system.
- **The Charter will continue to change and adapt** as AI tools and technologies evolve, and as patient, caregiver and healthcare system needs and policies about AI change.

We acknowledge and honour the patients' rights documents on AI in healthcare that came before this one. We see this Charter as a way to build on that work and bring patients, caregivers, healthcare providers and healthcare organizations together to create an environment of safety, partnership, and trust. We are deeply grateful to the patients and caregivers across Canada who contributed to this work. We look forward to seeing how this Charter will evolve and to the new dialogues, it will inspire.

-Future Skills Centre (FSC) AI in Healthcare Charter Advisory Committee

Building Trust in AI Healthcare

Who the Charter is for:

This Charter is for patients, healthcare providers and healthcare organizations. It aims to support relationships with each other, and with AI industry partners. It explains what patients and caregivers as a collective “we” expect. It describes how patients and caregivers want the system to actively build, foster, and sustain trustworthy practices that reflect their needs, while also respecting their knowledge and experience.

How it was developed:

After reviewing the existing research, and the health system about the needs of patients when AI is used in healthcare, we created a dialogue across Canada through surveys and interviews.

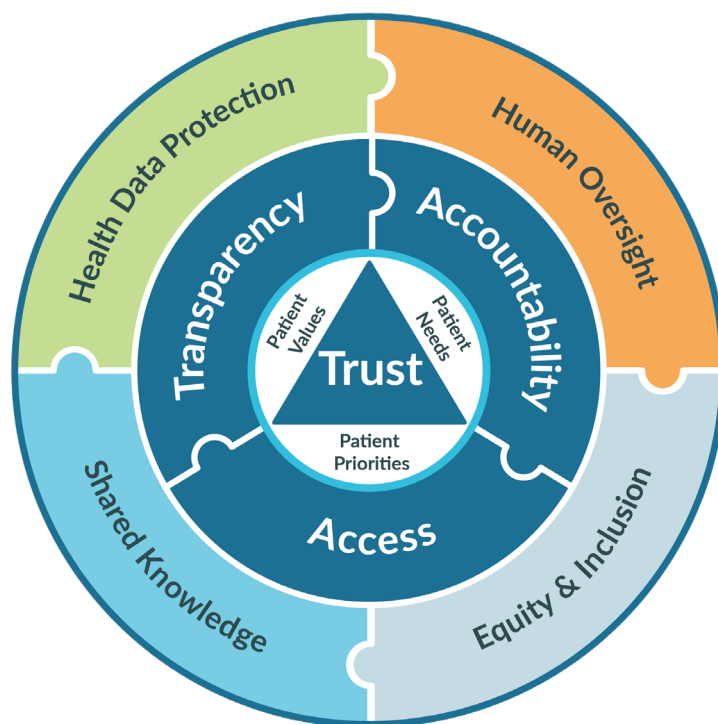
651 participants told us what mattered most to them when it comes to AI use in their healthcare.

Through careful analysis, we brought together what people shared in the surveys and interviews and what the research told us (see [References](#)). We held co-creations sessions with the Advisory Committee, providing a summary of the survey, interview findings, a glossary of terms and guiding principles for the Charter design, which we developed together.

The findings, along with the Committee’s insights, helped us develop a Charter that is rooted in the patient voice and truly reflective of what matters most to patients and caregivers.

The Pillars and Principles of building trust in AI healthcare.

- **Trust** is most important to patients and caregivers
- Trust grows, and is sustained, when **Accountability, Transparency, and fair Access** are prioritized (3 Pillars of Trust).
- The 3 Pillars of Trust are strengthened when the following **Principles** are consistently practised:
 1. Human Oversight
 2. Shared Knowledge
 3. Equity & Inclusion
 4. Health Data Protection

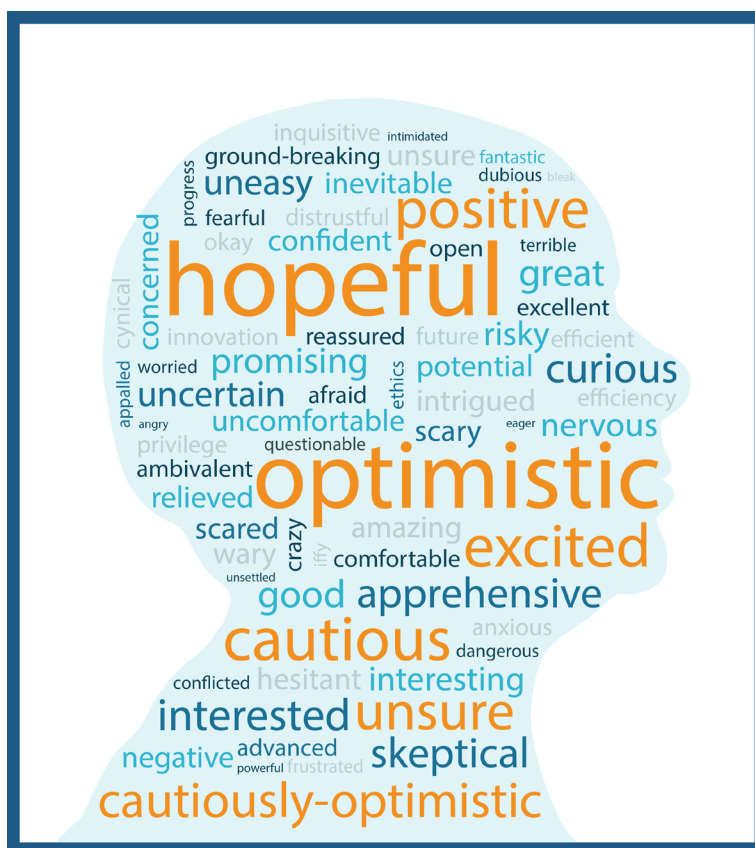


This Canadian dialogue revealed that patients and caregivers want a healthcare system that reflects their identities, lived experiences and diverse needs. Trusted, AI-enabled care means that AI systems must be designed and used in ways that treat people as a whole person, respects what people value, and helps create care that feels safe, inclusive and trustworthy.

Trust matters deeply and should not be assumed. Many have experienced historical or ongoing discrimination, and patients and caregivers want to be sure that AI does not introduce or reinforce bias or harm. Patients and caregivers were enthusiastic about the potential that AI can provide in relation to diagnostics, personalized medicine, and automating some administrative tasks, as long as the conditions outlined in this Charter are considered. They expressed that AI could support care, but human connection needs to stay at the heart of every interaction.

The Charter below first outlines the **3 Pillars of Trust: Accountability, Access and Transparency**, and why these are important.

After that, we have outlined the **Principles** and their associated **actions** that will ensure the pillars, and ultimately trust, are built into AI-enabled care.



This word cloud shows how patients and caregivers engaged in this work currently feel about AI.

The 3 Pillars of Trust

We see the pillars of Accountability, Access and Transparency as symbols of strength and stability that support trust in an AI-enabled healthcare system.

Pillar 1: Accountability



What we mean by Accountability:

- We ask for clear explanations so we can understand how AI is used in our care.
- We need to know how and why our [health data](#) is being collected, stored, accessed and used.
- It should be clear who is responsible for protecting our information. We should know what safeguards and controls are in place, especially when external vendors or partners are involved.
- We need to know that AI tools have been tested and that they work.
- We need our healthcare providers to always review, question, and validate what AI recommends. Decisions about our care must remain a shared responsibility between us and our providers, grounded in human judgment, compassion, and partnership.

Why Accountability Matters:

Accountability matters to us because it helps us feel safe. It reduces our fear and confusion, and reassures us that AI is supporting, not replacing, the human expertise and relationships essential to our care.

What patients and caregivers told us:

We need a clear governance structure so that if the AI fails, there are protocols to follow.

It is the future. You are not going to stop it. So how do we make it work right and make sure it is helpful and not harmful to everybody?

If you have safeguards built into the system and tell patients and caregivers that there will be no breach, even though nothing is 100% perfect, I'll trust it. Personal data should remain confidential unless I give permission for research use.

Pillar 2: Access



What we mean by Access:

We ask for clear explanations so we can understand how AI is used in our care.

- We need AI used in healthcare to serve all of us, fairly and inclusively.
- We want everyone to benefit from AI, across all languages, cultures, identities, ages and abilities.
- We need AI tools to reflect who we are and to work for everyone.
- Give us access to our own data and help us understand it, no matter what our digital skills or comfort with technology may be.
- Include patients and caregivers, along with diverse communities, in co-designing AI technology from the very beginning.
- Build AI programs that actively test for and address bias so that no one is harmed or left out.

Why Access Matters:

Accountability matters to us because it helps us feel safe. It reduces our fear and confusion, and reassures us that AI is supporting, not replacing, the human expertise and relationships essential to our care.

What patients and caregivers told us:

“AI should reflect who we are, sex, ethnicity, even body size trends, so it doesn't generalize from one group to everyone.”

“The fundamental requirement is to have patients or public representatives working with you in the design... participation in the creation of the rules and the governance.”

“Research has to be more inclusive and diversified to include under-represented demographic, cultural and sexually oriented groups. Only then can AI be trained to include all of us.”

Pillar 3: Transparency



What we mean by Transparency:

- Be open and honest with us about how AI is being used in our care.
- How our data is shared and used to create AI technologies, and what organizational policies are in place, is important for us to know and understand.

Why Transparency Matters:

Transparency matters to us because it helps us feel safe, seen, and respected. When we have clear information we can understand, we know efforts are being made to prevent errors and reduce bias. Experiences of exclusion are avoided, building the trust we need to confidently engage with AI in our care.

What patients and caregivers told us:

“

I want to know every time AI is used, explained in plain language, with a chance to ask questions and give or withhold consent based on the benefits, risks, and alternatives.

”

“

We give consent to the doctor or the facility for AI to be part of care. I would not give consent to AI itself without a human explanation. I would like a demo or trial before deciding.

”

“

I would want my healthcare professional to be upfront about it and inform me that it's happening. There needs to be ongoing oversight of the companies involved.”

”

Principles of the Pillars

We see the principles of Human Oversight, Equity & Inclusion, Shared Knowledge, and Health Data Protection as a way of translating the pillars above into clear actions and strengthening trust. We expect healthcare organizations and providers to practice these actions.

Principle: Human Oversight



What we mean by Human Oversight:

- We need our healthcare providers to know us as a whole person, to understand what is most important to us and our real-life situations.
- We acknowledge that AI can support our healthcare, but it cannot replace the relationships and human connections we have established.

Why Human Oversight Matters:

- Human oversight strengthens accountability.
- Our relationship with our healthcare providers is important to meeting our needs, and is especially important when it comes to AI. Putting this relationship first builds trust when AI is being used in our care.

Human Oversight in Action: Being Accountable, Transparent, and Accessible

- Partner with us to make decisions about our care. We need our healthcare providers, not just AI, to understand our preferences, priorities and lived experiences when making decisions about our lives.
- Stay present with us if AI tools are being used to generate notes during our appointment. Make eye contact, face us, and stay engaged. This helps us have meaningful and compassionate interactions. Technology should never get in the way of human connection when used in our care.
- Build strong, culturally safe and accountable frameworks that put human decision-making above AI in all clinical decisions.
- Know how AI is being used in our healthcare and share this with us in a transparent, easy to understand way.

What patients and caregivers told us:



You can't rely on technology to replace the humanity in healthcare, always remember there's a human in front of you.



I think AI can be very helpful, but I don't want it to only be AI, I want the person to critically review what AI is saying. Together with the human, why not have it help?

At decision points a human would normally make, be transparent that AI informed it, and tell me where that information came from.

Principle: Equity & Inclusion



What we mean by Equity & Inclusion:

- We each have different lived experiences, needs, and identities that must be considered when AI is created and developed.
- AI tools need to be fair, [culturally safe](#), and informed by our diverse identities, strengths, and knowledge.
- We want to be active partners in this work. Co-design of AI tools with patients, caregivers, and communities is essential to ensure these tools support all of us.

Why Equity and Inclusion Matters:

- Equity and inclusion strengthen fair access and transparency.
- When AI tools are built in a way that reflects all our identities, we will feel more confident in the care we receive.
- AI introduces new ways of accessing healthcare and we worry that the bias, generational trauma and exclusion many of us have already faced in the healthcare system could be repeated or even amplified through AI-enabled care.

Equity & Inclusion in Action: Being Accountable, Transparent, and Accessible

- Put clear accountability standards in place. Check AI systems often to make sure the data is tested for bias and the tools reflect the diverse backgrounds, identities, and experiences of the people they serve.
- Create simple, visual, and easy-to-understand resources that explain how AI is being used in our care. These tools should meet our language needs and be accessible no matter what our level of digital comfort.
- Build and test AI tools with a wide range of human attributes, communication styles, and lived experiences so they do not repeat or reinforce existing inequities. For example, partner with patients to identify these attributes that include elements like accents, skin colour, disabilities, languages, etc.

- Work in true partnership with patients, caregivers, and communities with diverse experiences to co-design AI solutions. Be open about how our ideas, concerns, and lived experiences shape the design and decisions behind these solutions.
- Create an emotionally safe space for us using a [trauma-informed approach](#). Provide care in a way that shows you understand the effects of our trauma and are being sensitive to those experiences.

What patients and caregivers told us:

Diversity in the datasets that AI is being trained on and the nuances for different ethnicities, sex, height, weight otherwise the AI outputs and recommendations would be misleading and erode trust.

The fundamental requirement is to have patients or public representatives working with you in the design... participation in the creation of the rules and the governance.

It depends on the context, models trained on broad datasets don't have the ability to capture smaller populations with rare conditions.

Principle: Shared Knowledge



What we mean by Shared Knowledge:

- Shared Knowledge refers to clear, easy-to understand information. It includes information about how our health data is collected, what consent means, how AI may be used in our care and how our data will be used to build AI tools.
- We need this information to be shared in ways that match our learning styles, our level of digital comfort, our language preferences, and our accessibility needs.
- Our healthcare providers also need knowledge about AI so they can offer person-centred care and work with us in a way that builds our confidence, compassion, and trust in AI-enabled healthcare.

Why Shared Knowledge Matters:

- Shared Knowledge strengthens access and transparency. This gives us a sense of control over our health and makes us feel more comfortable, confident and trusting of AI being used in our care.
- Understanding how AI is governed in organizations, and their relationships with external vendors, is important for having a sense of control over our health.

Shared Knowledge in Action: Being Accountable, Transparent, and Accessible

- Use plain language and clear communication to help us understand how AI and [machine learning](#) are being used in our care. Tell us of what kinds of health data were used to train these AI technologies.
- Teach our healthcare providers about AI and help build their digital and data literacy. This allows them to explain things to us in a way we can understand and makes us feel more reassured and in control.
- Listen and try to understand our experiences. Respect the knowledge we have about our own health and the preferences we have about our care.

What patients and caregivers told us:

“*There should be system-wide consistency so patients don't get different explanations in different departments.*”

“*If I'm going to trust it, I need to know how it works in my care.*”

“*Clinicians need to understand AI well enough to explain it to patients.*”

Principle: Health Data Protection



What we mean by Health Data Protection:

- Our health data belongs to us. How our data is shared and used to create AI technologies, and what organizational policies are in place, is important for us to know and understand.
- We want to know that our information is treated with respect, protected with strong safeguards, and handled in ways that reflect our values.
- When our data is being shared with external vendors, we need clear, transparent information about the intended uses and the accountability agreements in place to keep our data safe.
- We trust our healthcare providers to be responsible for ensuring our data is being used safely.

Why Health Data Protection Matters:

- Protection of our health data strengthens accountability and transparency.
- Our comfort and trust grow when we have data practices that are thoroughly screened, regularly reviewed, and continuously monitored.

- Accessing and using our health data can make some of us feel vulnerable, especially for patients with a history of healthcare-related trauma

Health Data Protection in Action: Being Accountable, Transparent, and Accessible

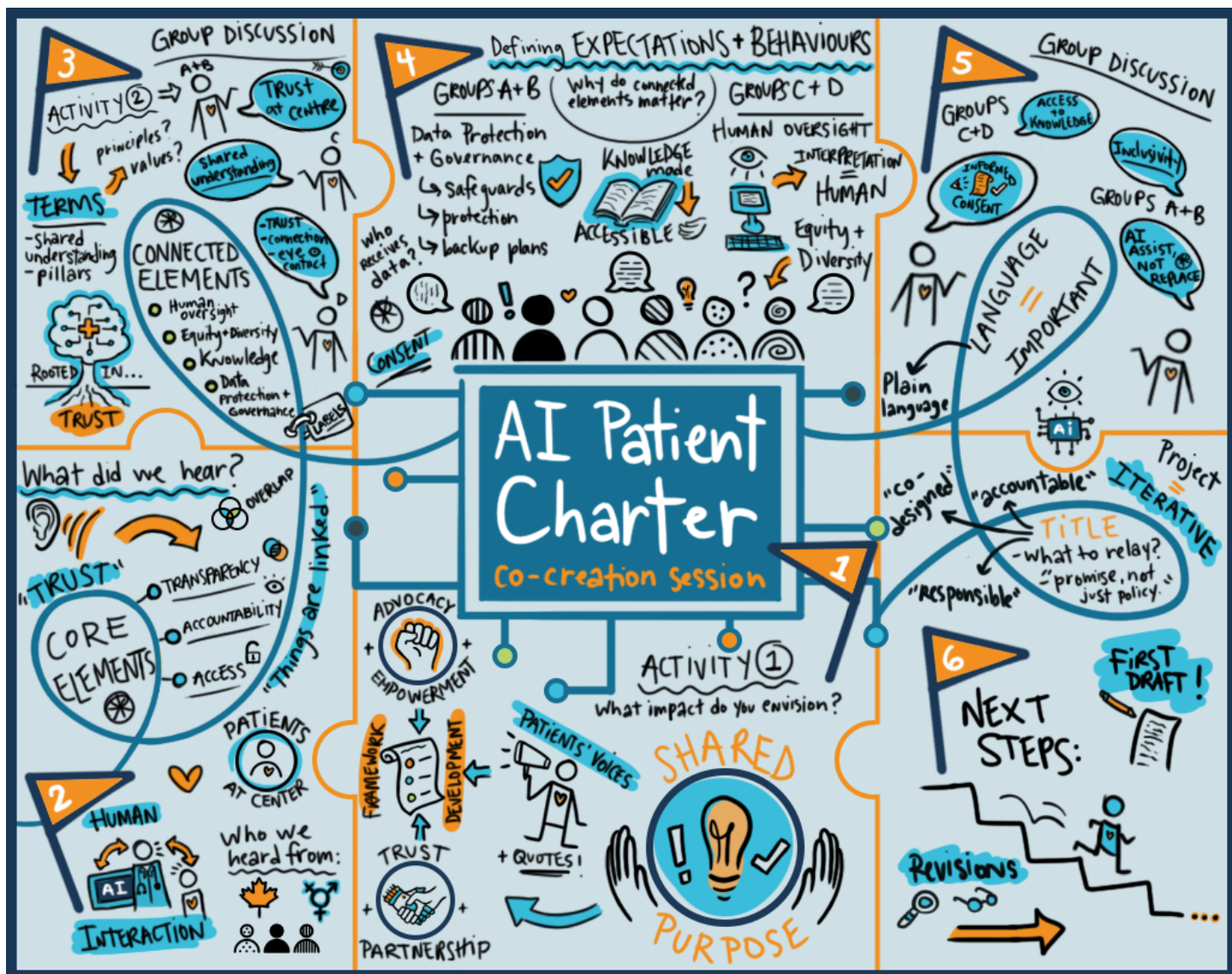
- Support our need to understand the organizational privacy laws regarding the use of our health data for the design of AI. Be transparent about how organizations share health data with external vendors in line with these laws.
- Engage with patients and caregivers to understand their priorities and preferences for the use of health data as AI evolves.
- Be open about how our data is being protected when it is used to create or train AI tools, and share what safety measures are in place.
- Clarify and share who is responsible for setting policies and standards for AI use in our healthcare organization.
- Ensure there is a clear, easy way for patients and caregivers to ask questions and get answers.

What patients and caregivers told us:

Having AI in healthcare would be great, but data protection is key. I'd like assurance, maybe even a statement, that my information is safe and not used to improve a model without my consent.

I would like that level of control over my data, to say no or yes, and maybe explain why. People who've experienced stigma or bias should have that right.

Well, it is your information. You have ownership over it and the right to choose what you want or don't want to be used, unless it may pose harm to others.



This graphic recording depicts one of the steps in our Journey of Co-Creation with the Advisory Committee. This was a session where deep discussions about the patient voice data occurred. It captures the essence of what Committee Members found important to include in the Charter.

Glossary

Artificial Intelligence:

In the context of this project, Artificial Intelligence (AI) means computer systems that can do things usually done by people, such as finding patterns, making predictions, or helping with decisions. AI systems learn from large sets of information, like medical records or test result. They are designed to follow specific rules. In some healthcare spaces, AI is used to support patients, caregivers, and health-care professionals.

Source: [Ethics and governance of artificial intelligence for health](#)

Bias (in AI):

Systematic errors or unfairness in the outcomes, predictions, or decisions made by AI Systems. These biases can arise from various stages of an AI system's lifecycle, such as during data collection, model design, training, or deployment. AI bias often reflects or amplifies biases present in the data, processes, or assumptions used to build the system. It can lead to unequal or discriminatory outcomes, affecting fairness, accuracy, and trustworthiness of an AI system.

Source: [9. Definitions - Accessibility Standards Canada](#)

Charter:

A formal document that publicly declares a set of commitments, rights, responsibilities, or guiding principles agreed upon by a group or institution. It often establishes shared expectations and serves as a moral or policy reference point.

Source: synthesized definition

Cultural Safety:

Cultural safety is about the experience of the patient. It is an outcome based on respectful engagement that recognizes and strives to address power imbalances inherent in the healthcare system. It results in an environment free of racism and discrimination, where people feel safe when receiving health care.

Source: [Common Definitions on Cultural Safety: Chief Public Health Officer Health Professional Forum - Canada.ca](#)

Health Data:

Health data is a general term that can include information about the health status of individuals and the health services that individuals receive. Examples of health data include visits to health care providers or health facilities, prescription medications, laboratory test results, demographic, and social determinants of health.

Source: [Health Data Research Network Canada](#)

Healthcare organization:

A public or private entity responsible for delivering, managing, or coordinating health services. This includes hospitals, primary care practices, community health centres, public health units, long-term care homes, Indigenous health organizations, and other agencies that provide or support patient care within Canada's health system.

Source: [About Canada's health care system - Canada.ca](#)

Healthcare provider:

An individual or organization licensed or authorized to deliver health services. This includes professionals such as physicians, nurses, pharmacists, dentists, therapists, and midwives, as well as clinics, hospitals, and community care organizations.

Source: [Access to health care](#)

Machine Learning:

A type of artificial intelligence that enables computer systems to learn patterns from data and improve their performance over time without being explicitly programmed.

Source: [What is Machine Learning? | IBM](#)

Trauma-Informed Care:

A framework recognizing trauma's widespread impact. It aims to create safe, trustworthy environments, promote choice and control, build strengths, and avoid re-traumatization by understanding how past adverse experiences affect individuals' well-being, behaviour, and health.

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